

ARGUMENT STRUCTURE IN THE MW PRACTICAL

A large proportion of the marks available in the MW practical exam are for arguments (for identity, quality etc). This allows you an opportunity to do the following:

- When your identification is correct, convince the examiner it is not just a lucky guess
- When your identification is incorrect, convince the examiner that at least you have tasted the wine accurately (levels of structural components, aromatic character, general quality and style), and that your incorrect answer is a plausible one.
- Whether your identification is correct or not, demonstrate to the examiner your knowledge of the world of wine styles.

The way you structure your answer can have a huge impact on how successfully you do all of these. Part of your preparation for the exam will be working on increasing your 'hit rate' (the percentage of wines you identify correctly). But even if you can get your hit rate to over 75%, this will just be an average, and there is a good chance you will fall well below this on one of the flights in one of the three papers – enough to lead to a fail overall. And even if your hit rate is this high, you still need to convince the examiner that you didn't just get lucky. (My hit rate was about 60%).

Good argument is not a substitute for poor tasting. The evidence you use in your arguments still needs to be read fairly accurately from the glass. But we are all human, and will make some errors. Good argument structures will help you

- Quickly identify and make use the most pertinent evidence in each wine
- Pick up marks for the aspects of each wine that you have assessed correctly
- decrease the luck element of the practical exam (you will be able to take advantage of good luck, but can fall back on sound exam technique, rather than panic, if you have a difficult flight).

There are many ways to structure sound arguments. One of the most important skills is to be flexible – to be able to select the evidence you use, and the argument structure you use, in a way that is appropriate to

- the amount of space and marks awarded to the answer
- how confident you are about your conclusion
- which evidence sings most clearly for the particular wine or wines in front of you.

This will cover how to select evidence and details of a set of techniques that are generally described together as funnelling. It will also discuss how best to select evidence, and how to use 'argument words' to link your evidence appropriately to your conclusions.

I wrote another paper on how to prepare for the exams, where I defined the following types of answer:
Type 1 –you are very confident as to the identity, but must make sure you get 20-25 marks for these wines.

Type 2 –you have some idea what the wine is, and you certainly know what general kind of wine it is (quality, style), and need to ensure you get 15-20 marks for each of these.

Type 3 –you are really puzzled, but you need to write something. Proceed cautiously, and read the evidence in the glass (especially for quality and style) closely so you get 10-15 marks for each of these.

You do not need all of your answers to be type 1. As long as the type 1 answers outnumber the type 3 (and you argue convincingly), this averages out at 17.5/25 or 70% -a pass.

Funnelling

Funnelling is a way of moving from a larger set of possible answers to a final selection. Compared to just considering one possibility, funnelling offers the following advantages:

- Your final answer may be correct, but if you have funnelled well, the correct answer will be one of the wines you have considered, and you will have eliminated it for plausible reasons –thus gaining marks.
- (If you have funnelled well) you not only pick the correct answer, but you show the examiner convincingly why this is the correct answer.

The disadvantages are that (a) funnelling tends to take time and words, and (b) it can make your answer seem to lack confidence. But there are ways of dealing with both of these problems.

When to Funnel

Should you always funnel? This depends on how well you can produce a compelling non-funnel answer; how confident you are in your identification; and whether you are correct. If you stand any chance of being incorrect, a direct (non-funnel) answer is a high risk tactic, and a mini-funnel almost certainly makes better use of your time.

Direct (Non-Funnel) Answers

Consider the alternative to the funnel answer. You have a wine where you are 100% sure as to the identity. Then you are lucky indeed! But how do you argue for this? If you 'just know' what it is, and can't explain how you 'just know', then you are in a bit of trouble. The examiner wants your reasons. A simple tasting note ('pale lemon colour, medium 13% alcohol....') describing the wine will get you some marks, probably enough to pass that section (because your identification is correct), but for the wines you get correct, you really should be getting 20+/25, to make up for the wines you will get wrong. In the years you spend in the program, you should have time to build up a bank of arguments for the few wines that really can be identified this definitively.

There are two key elements to a successful, compelling direct answer.

- 1) You should identify which are the killer pieces of evidence in the wine. These are pieces of evidence that distinguish the wine from a generic dry white or dry red, and also distinguish your chosen answer from a generic dry white or dry red.
- 2) In combination you should be able to list your chosen evidence and be able to say 'the combination of X, Y and Z means this wine (or these wines) **could only possibly be** [whatever conclusion you jump to]'

Killer Evidence: 'leads to' versus 'is consistent with'

One of the most important skills for you to gain (beyond WSET Diploma tasting skills) is the ability to select the distinguishing features of a wine from among the characteristics that are more generic. The remarkable, distinguishing features constitute the evidence that take you in a particular direction, rather than just describing the wine (which is the focus for WSET Diploma). The generic characteristics are merely things that must be consistent with your choice. The skill of dividing evidence into these two categories is needed for funnel, as well as direct answers. But the success of direct answers is especially dependent on your ability to make this distinction quickly.

There is nothing wrong with describing the level of a structural component as 'medium' or 'medium +', but for the purposes of selecting evidence for arguments, you should think of 'medium' as meaning the same as 'unremarkable'. An unremarkable level of anything is unlikely to be useful evidence. The following are examples of unremarkable evidence:

- Pale or medium lemon colour, watery rim (whites)
- Medium ruby colour (reds)
- Alcohol between 12.5% and 13.5%
- Medium body, medium acidity, medium level of tannins, dry.
- (there are more...)

Within arguments, the only legitimate place for this kind of evidence is when you are excluding wines that have remarkable characteristics. ('moderate (13%) alcohol excludes Amarone'... 'acid is only medium, which makes Sauvignon Blanc and Riesling unlikely')

Otherwise this kind of evidence is best saved for a 'mopping up' sentence at the end of your argument, showing you have considered all aspects of the wine, assessed them accurately, and know that they are consistent with your choice. Whether or not you include such a mopping up sentence is your choice. If your argument is already completely compelling without it, then this final (fairly long) sentence might gain you an extra mark or two at most, and the time could be better spent getting the key points down in another paragraph.

As part of your preparation for the exam, I highly recommend that for a number of classic styles (listed in my 'how to prepare' doc), you know in your mind what the killer pieces of evidence are.

...'could only possibly be'....

If you are any less sure than 100% that your conclusion is the only possible wine consistent with your listed evidence, then it is usually prudent to use at least some kind of funnelling. Reaching this level of confidence requires you to develop your tastings skills, but it also requires the wine to state very clearly what it is, and that in turn requires it to be something quite unique in style. How many wines is it really possible to do this for? Even assuming a Platonically perfect representative of the wine, and assuming you are tasting accurately? Consider these:

- The wine is dry and fortified to a low level (15% abv), shows no evidence of oxidation in the appearance (pale lemon) or aroma (fresh). This, together with the overt presence of flor aromas (bread, yeast) means **this wine could only possibly be** Fino Sherry.
- Such an overt, pungent varietal expression of Sauvignon Blanc (fruity/floral passion fruit and herbaceous nettle and tomato leaf) **could only possibly** come from Marlborough, New Zealand.
- The medium ruby colour, bright cherry fruit, light tannins, moderate (13% alcohol) and high acid mean this wine **could only possibly be** Barbera d'Alba.

I think Fino Sherry is unique enough that this style of answer works. I don't believe this is the case for Marlborough Sauvignon, and certainly not the case for Barbera –there are too many other similar wines, and typical Barbera is too close to a generic red.

If you are arguing so directly for a wine, you need the examiner not to be thinking 'yes, that combination of evidence is consistent with your choice, but what about a number of other wines that fit that description'. If there are exceptions (which, in the complicated world of wine, there always will be), they should be obscure enough that you can legitimately ignore them. I call this the '*ignoring the obscure*' caveat. It tacitly preceded every sentence I wrote in my exam.

With the '*ignoring the obscure*' caveat, the first of these arguments is probably sound. (I am sure there are producers in Australia making Fino styles with some success, which would meet this description, but I don't think the examiner would expect me to tell the difference between a real Fino and a convincing New World copy. The fortified level excludes Tokaji Szamorodni Szaraz and Vin Jaune (as would the moderate acid level and lack of any varietal fruit if I had mentioned those aspects). The dominating flor character and lack of oxidation excludes other Sherry styles, apart from pale cream (which is excluded by the dryness of this wine). These are the wines I might have considered as part of a funnel answer, but such an answer would have been at least twice as long.

The second of these arguments is not totally convincing. There are South African and Chilean Sauvignons that fit this description –and these wines are not obscure. I have thrown away an opportunity to demonstrate to the examiner that I can describe the typical stylistic differences between Marlborough, premium South African, and premium Chilean Sauvignon. Worse, I have created the impression that I think only Marlborough produces Sauvignon in the overt, varietally expressive style. It would be better to start with the evidence pointing to a premium New World Sauvignon (which I

am 100% sure this wine is), and then use the particularly complete spectrum of varietal expression to lead me to Marlborough over South Africa (generally more herbaceous; less fruity/floral) or Chile (generally more fruity, less herbaceous).

The third of these arguments is of little use at all. There are plenty of wines that fit this description (Beaujolais, basic Valpolicella and Bardolino, and of course other Italian Barberas, but even a lot of basic New World Pinot Noirs are not excluded). Also, muddled in with the 'killer evidence' (the high acid, low tannin structure and the bright fresh red fruit) is unremarkable evidence that just happens to be true of the wine, rather than being compelling evidence of identity (the colour, the alcohol level).

Direct answers have the great advantage of brevity, so it is helpful to be able to write them for a few of your identification answers, to save you time elsewhere. This is especially the case where 7-10 marks are available for identification, where you are confident you are correct. Even if it is possible you are incorrect the time saved *might* be spent effectively gaining marks elsewhere. This is why I think it is useful at the start of the paper to select one or two wines where you are going to write a 'type 1' answer –show absolute confidence, go for the kill, and be succinct. And save time.

How can they be used best? TO summarise, my tips are:

- Only use non-funnel answers when you are extremely confident of your answer (the type 1).
- Focus on the killer evidence. What makes this wine special, and what makes your chosen identity special.
- IF THERE IS TIME, it can be useful to add a second/final sentence mopping up the 'non-killer' evidence, just to show that you have taken it into account, tasting the wine completely and accurately, and all other pieces of evidence are consistent with your choice.
- Ask yourself honestly if there are any other non-obscure wines that fit your selected combination of evidence. If there are, you need to think again (either gain more evidence or use a different answer structure).

When I passed the practical exam in 2007, I did not use any direct answers: I always funnelled.

First steps beyond the non-funnel answer

If you are 90% sure you know the identity of a wine, but there is a small chance it could be something else, then there is a kind of mid-way-between-direct-answer-and-funneling structure. This starts with the direct answer (with all its advantages of brevity, directness), but adds some other possibilities at the end. Taking the Marlborough Sauvignon answer from above, this would become:

- Such an overt, pungent varietal expression of Sauvignon Blanc (fruity/floral passion fruit and herbaceous nettle and tomato leaf) **could only possibly** come from Marlborough, New Zealand. Premium South African Sauvignons are generally more green/herbaceous and less fruity; and Premium Chilean Sauvignons generally have less intense pyrazine character than this one.

Whatever you think the wine is, and no matter how certain you are, it is worth imagining the moment when the list of wines comes out after the exam, and finding out that you got it wrong. If you had got it wrong, what could be the possible correct identities of the wine? If there really is nothing else the wine could be then you can leave your answer as a direct one. If there are one or (maximum two) other possibilities, you could deal with them this way.

Funnel Answers

The two aims of the funnel answer are

- 1) to ensure that you get credit for identifying the kind of wine (style, quality) correctly, even if you don't get the exact identity correct
- 2) To demonstrate to the examiner that you know where to look for evidence to distinguish between the wines you have in your funnelling shortlist, i.e. demonstrate your depth of knowledge of the world of wine styles, and how wines typically differ from each other.

There are several steps to a funnel answer. Each step can be made in more, or less, detail, and with more, or less caution. The fullest, most detailed way is to proceed step by step, securing each piece of evidence and each conclusion one at a time. But you can (and should) truncate this to adapt funnelling to different levels of confidence and different amounts of space on the paper.

All funnel answers have the following underlying steps:

- 1) Creation of the shortlist
- 2) Consideration of evidence that eliminates items in the shortlist
- 3) Consideration of evidence that is consistent with the shortlist
- 4) Mopping up evidence that is consistent with the final choice.

Steps 2 and 3 may be reversed, or even worked through bit-by-bit in alternation. Step 4 is not always necessary –sometimes it can just waste time

With arguments using evidence from multiple wines, there can be a fifth step

5) Discussing how aspects of particular wines are especially typical of your final choice. (However, with such questions, there will almost certainly be a chance to use this evidence later on. For example, if you have used the exceptional high quality, elegance, finesse of tannins and purity and freshness of cassis fruit as demonstrating Cabernet Sauvignon as expressed in high quality Bordeaux, you will probably use this evidence later when identifying the region of each of the wines). I would only use this fifth step if I had completed the whole tasting paper and was going back through fleshing out some answers. Or, if there was one wine that was not typical for the variety (say) I was arguing for, but wanted to show how it could be consistent, if it came from a particular region or vintage.

The first step (creation of the shortlist) helps with the first aim (credit for identifying the kind of wine). The next two steps help with the second (looking for evidence, distinguishing, showing off knowledge of how wines differ). All of these require you to use evidence to draw conclusions.

The trick is to use as much pertinent evidence as possible before you make any steps in the wrong direction, while at the same time making your argument as succinct and direct as possible. Easier said than done! But the easiest way to do this well is to think about how the shape of your funnel relates to your level of confidence. At one extreme, if you are very confident (but have decided wisely to funnel, rather than write a direct answer), your funnel might be small at the top (just consider a few possibilities) and then eliminate them quickly. Taking the Sauvignon Blanc example where I am absolutely 100% sure this is a premium New World Sauvignon (but which might possibly come from somewhere other than Marlborough):

- *The high quality, purity of fruit and the overtly fruit-driven, pungent varietal expression of Sauvignon Blanc indicate a Premium New World cool climate region such as Marlborough (New Zealand) or cooler sites in South Africa or Chile. The high acid is typical with all three of these. Premium South African Sauvignons are generally more green/herbaceous and less fruity; and Premium Chilean Sauvignons generally have less intense pyrazine character than this one, and the full spectrum of aromatic varietal expression –fruity thiols and herbaceous pyrazines is particularly typical of Marlborough.*

(I could add a last sentence saying that the unoaked, dry, medium bodied style with medium (13.5%) abv is consistent with this choice).

And taking the Barbera as an example of more cautious funnelling:

- *The bright, fresh cherry fruit; vibrant acidity and light tannins suggest Beaujolais, Valpolicella, or Italian Barbera. The bright ruby colour, absence of oak, medium body and alcohol (13%) are consistent with all three choices. At this quality level, Valpolicella tannins might typically be a little more green and stemmy, and Beaujolais would show more evidence of carbonic maceration (kirsch like aromas). This makes Barbera the most likely choice.*

Here, almost all aspects of the wine have been considered before making the final choice. If the wine were a Beaujolais, the I have at least shown this was a serious possibility, and looked in the right place for evidence to make my decision.

Creation of the Shortlist

Your shortlist can be a list of particular wines ('Barbera, basic Chianti, basic Valpolicella or Beaujolais'; 'Cabernet Sauvignon or Shiraz') or it can be a kind of wine described in more abstract terms ('Premium old world cool climate region'; 'semi-aromatic white grape variety suitable for unoaked styles').

You have two aims:

- 1) For the true identity of the wine to be in your shortlist, and for the way you describe your shortlist (if in abstract terms) to correctly describe the true identity of the wine.
- 2) For the evidence you draw on to get to the shortlist to be true about the wine and your shortlist.

If you manage both of these, then you are scoring points right up to the point you make the wrong turn in the elimination section.

There are two approaches to generating your shortlist. In a Kantian spirit I will call these the analytic and the synthetic.

The **synthetic** approach starts with a list of particular possibilities. Some candidates found it helpful to write lists of grape varieties, countries, regions, at the start of the exam so they would not forget possibilities. If you do this, you can work through the list, eliminate the impossible and you are left with a list of particular plausibles. Anything you name at the shortlist stage, you need to eliminate in the next stage (or the examiner will be looking at a gap in your argument, wondering if it is deliberate slight-of-hand). This means for practical purposes, shortlists of more than about four items are not very manageable. If your synthetically generated shortlist is longer than this, return to your evidence and see which ones you can eliminate most securely. Note that a synthetically generated shortlist should have some kind of logic –there should be shared characteristics (and these shared characteristics form the evidence in the part of the sentence preceding the naming of the shortlist).

The **analytic** approach starts with the whole world of wine, and subdivides it into manageable sections. For example, regions can be divided into Old World or New World, Hot or Cool climate, and regions where there is evidence of premium quality potential versus more generic growing areas. Grape varieties can be classed as thick or thin skinned, or Bordeaux varieties (pyrazines), or as fully aromatic, semi-aromatic and non-aromatic. The great advantage of an analytic shortlist is that you can describe your shortlist in abstract terms easily. This is quicker than listing all the possibilities. It also means that if the correct identity is not in your shortlist, but falls within the category your shortlist describes, you pick up marks for correctly identifying the kind of wine. For example, if our Sauvignon Blanc came from Martinborough, everything up to the point of saying 'Premium New World Cool Climate region' would be true. The reasons for eliminating South Africa and Chile would also be valid. The only slip would have been not to consider Martinborough. (which I wouldn't do anyway!).

Some regions and styles fall neatly into analytic categories –this tends to be true of premium regions making wines from international grape varieties. Others do not fall into such categories easily. This tends to be the case if the quality level is good rather than outstanding, and if there is no particular evidence towards climate, or with grape varieties with little in the way of clear distinguishing features. I recommend you use the analytic approach whenever you can, but be able to draw on the synthetic approach where the analytic one lets you down. (Rather than simply panicking because the tools you have don't do the job you need them to do).

In the time ahead of the exam, you can work on converting synthetic shortlists into analytic ones –to benefit from the advantages described above (brevity, and being better for gathering marks). Whenever you make errors in identification, think about what the correct identity and your guess have in common. Do this when discussing wine styles with other MW candidates –what errors do they make? This is the process of building up a catalogue of ‘laterals’ –wines that can reasonably be mistaken for each other.

Unfortunately, wines do not divide themselves very neatly into discrete clusters of laterals, and depending on your strengths as a taster (aromatic, structural, quality evaluation), what is a lateral for you might not be a lateral for others. You also need to consider the particular wine in front of you. Some Coonawarra Cabernets might taste like Coonawarra Shiraz; whereas for others the nearest lateral might be Margaret River Cabernet (or even Chilean Carmenere). With the Barbera example, I can think of examples of Barbera that I might mistake for a Bourgogne Rouge, and others where I might mistake them for Chianti. It is unlikely I would mistake Bourgogne Rouge for Chianti (nothing is impossible). In the exam, I wouldn’t just list my ‘laterals for Barbera’ –I would pick laterals appropriate to the wine in front of me.

For any wine style, once you have made a few mistakes in identification, the next step is to abstract from those errors whatever it is they have in common. This can be the basis of abstract/analytic shortlists. Using the Barbera example, what is it that modest quality Barbera has in common with Beaujolais and basic Valpolicella? High acid, lowish tannin, absence of oak, fresh fruit are the shared distinguishing features (colour body and alcohol are also shared but these are unremarkable). So perhaps the first sentence could be

- *The wine belongs to the category of unoaked, fruity, high acid reds with low tannins, and the fresh but restrained simple cherry fruit puts it in the Old World (but not necessarily from a premium location). Beaujolais, Valpolicella, Italian Barbera are all possible. The bright ruby colour, medium body and alcohol (13%) are consistent with all three choices. At this quality level, Valpolicella tannins might typically be a little more green and stemmy, and Beaujolais would show more evidence of carbonic maceration (kirsch like aromas). This makes Barbera the most likely choice.*

The advantage of shortlisting an abstract ‘kind’ of wine before getting to specifics is that if the true identity of the wine is not one of the ones I have listed (it is a basic quality Blaufränkisch, or a very basic Bourgogne rouge, or Spanish unoaked Tempranillo, for example), I have at least indicated that I have identified the basic style and quality level correctly.

This is how you avoid dropping much below 60% for those wines you misidentify.

Consideration of evidence that eliminates items in the shortlist

Having generated a shortlist, you need to find a path to your final answer. This is where your theoretical knowledge of wine styles, and your ability to argue soundly are put most to the test. This is also the part where you have the opportunity to gain credit for your reasoning. In a direct answer, you will still (probably) have gone through some kind of reasoning process in your head –even if it is just to convince yourself that you have the correct answer. Why not gain credit for putting your reasoning on the page for the benefit of the examiner?

In order to do this stage well, you first need to know how wines differ from each other. Of course, within any category of wine, there is a spectrum of styles and qualities that overlaps with other wine categories. For the purposes of the MW exam, you have to assume that the wines chosen will sit in the middle of their category (at least in the minds of the examiners selecting the wines. OR, if a maverick wine is chosen (a very modern Rioja, or an oaked Marlborough Sauvignon), you as a candidate will not be identifying it based on its typicity. So, if ‘Platonic ideals’ are used in the exam (as far as possible), you need to know how these differ from each other.

There are many ways to find out this theoretical information, and it is best to use these in combination.

Firstly, you need to build a catalogue of knowledge of how the categories differ. You should combine practical and theory sources –they can reinforce or challenge each other. Many wine books have good descriptions of how grape varieties differ from each other, and of how regional styles for each grape variety differ (Oz Clarke and Margaret Rand's book is particularly good for this). You should also discuss with other experts: how do they describe the typical difference between two types of wine (Asking this question can be fascinating, for the contradictory diversity of and often utter jawdropping meaningfulness of answers some wine professionals give with great panache and swagger. Fortunately, with patience and speaking to the right people, you can find gold).

On the practical side, it is possible to build up your own picture by tasting widely. This has several disadvantages, however: it is very time consuming (especially when you consider the number of wine styles to cover). You need to taste huge numbers of Californian and Australian Chardonnays (for example) at a wide range of price points before you are in a position to say 'x, y, and z are the factors that will help me identify and argue whether a premium Chardonnay is from California or Australia'. Also, there is a high risk that the factors you abstract from your experience will be a contingent result of the subset of wine you happened to be able to taste, rather than the true difference. And even if you manage to identify the real differences, these may not be the ones the examiners expect.

For this reason, you should combine the practical with the theoretical. Start with the biggest categories (Cabernet versus Shiraz....) then narrow down (old world versus new world...) and narrow down further (California versus Australia; Tuscany versus Bordeaux...) and a little further still (Coonawarra versus Margaret River...) but don't go mad. A good candidate might be able to put forward an argument for benchland versus mountain Cabernet, but getting the Cabernet correctly in Napa is as much as most of the best candidates will achieve, and worrying about Rutherford versus Oakville or Howell versus Veeder versus Spring is too much. Life is too short to do that for all the regions that might come up. How far do you go? I suggest the WSET Level 2 Award in Wines provides a good guide to the list of regions for each international grape variety. Within each international grape variety, you should be able to take any pair of premium regions and come up with 2-3 pieces of evidence that capture the difference between the wine styles from those regions.

Once you have the beginning of the bank of distinguishing evidence, you are at the point where practical tasting can help you refine, expand, correct.

Tim Wildman MW is an advocate of the 'two glass tasting'. At tasting events it is of little value to you (as an MW candidate) to know what any particular wine tastes like. What matters is how wines differ. This is my suggestion for how to gain this knowledge

1. From books, discussion with other professionals or students, or from your mentor (within reason!), or from your existing tasting experience, generate a hypothesis for how to distinguish between a pair of wines. Do this for a number of wine pairs. You can do this in your head (I did) or write it down (I wish I did). As an example, 'compared to Puligny, Meursault is typically richer textured/fuller bodied, rounder, deeper, more nutty, whereas Puligny has more prominent acidity, more elegance, subtler oak, and fresher more floral aromas'.
2. With a hypothesis like this I can go to a Burgundy tasting (I am lucky –I am in London and can do this almost any day) and put this hypothesis to the test, by tasting pairs of Puligny and Meursault side by side. Same producer, same vintage, lots of wines. Does my hypothesis stand up to scrutiny? Hopefully, if it doesn't, I will have tasted enough wines to come up with something to replace it.

Focussing on the wines in the WSET Level 2 syllabus keeps this manageable. If you can do this really thoroughly for those wines, you are well prepared theoretically for the 'elimination' part of funnelling.

In addition to a solid theoretical knowledge of how wines differ from each other, you need to know how to present your process in the form of an argument. Each sentence should be in the form of

Evidence.....argument link.....conclusion

Generally you should use two or three pieces of evidence to support a conclusion. Isolated pieces of evidence are rarely compelling on their own. For example, high acid could be due to cool ripening conditions, or early harvesting (in hot conditions) or it could be a varietal characteristic –or it could have been adjusted. High acid *together with* breadth of aromatic development might more strongly suggest slow ripening in cool conditions.

Your argument link should be appropriate. If you are confident, use a strong word ('points directly to'...'strongly indicates'). If you are less confident, or the evidence is weaker, then adjust your language accordingly ('suggests'...'makes X less likely'...). Remember always to distinguish between 'remarkable' evidence (that takes you in a particular direction) and unremarkable, generic evidence (which at best is consistent with your choice).

Your conclusion should follow from your evidence. This means the evidence you have cited should draw on your bank of distinguishing factors, and the examiner should not read your argument and immediately be thinking of non-obscure counterexamples.

Consideration of evidence that is consistent with the shortlist Mopping up evidence that is consistent with the final choice.

The purpose of both of these is to ensure you have used, and considered all the evidence in the glass. If your argument is completely compelling without them, then it may be prudent to move on to other parts of the exam. But, especially in the larger paragraphs (e.g. where 20+ marks are available for identifying a country, region, variety, vintage...) each of these can be done in a single sentence. If you are very confident of your final choice, I would suggest only doing the last mopping up sentence. If you want to show the examiner you have several possibilities you would like to consider seriously (as with the Barbera example below), then do the first, or both.

- *The wine belongs to the category of unoaked, fruity, high acid reds with low tannins, and the fresh but restrained simple cherry fruit puts it in the Old World (but not from a premium location). Beaujolais, Valpolicella, Italian Barbera are all possible. **The bright ruby colour, medium body and alcohol (13%) are consistent with all three choices.** At this quality level, Valpolicella tannins might typically be a little more green and stemmy, and Beaujolais would show more evidence of carbonic maceration (kirsch like aromas). This makes Barbera the most likely choice.*